

A California Cruise.

Narrative of a Woman who lived eighteen years alone, upon the Island of San Nicolas.

Capt. C. J. W. Russell, who will be recollected by the readers of the *Bulletin* as the writer of many valuable articles in its columns on the subject of "California Fisheries," has contributed to Hutchings's *Magazine* an interesting narrative of a woman who lived eighteen years alone upon the Island of San Nicolas, one of the Santa Barbara group, off the lower coast, and situated about $33^{\circ} 15'$ North latitude. While stationed in that quarter, making tidal observations for the United States Government, Capt. Russell received from one George Nedevir, an old California resident, the following remarkable history :

Twenty years ago, the whole of the Indian tribes inhabiting the Santa Barbara group of islands were engaged in a fierce and exterminating war with each other, and to such an extent was this deadly hostility waged that already the population had very much diminished, and would, in all probability, before many years, become entirely extinct. To prevent this, and at the same time to ameliorate the condition of the Indians, the good Fathers of the Mission of Santa Barbara conceived the idea of removing them to the main land, where they might be watched over, improved, and preserved, under their immediate superintendence. For this purpose they visited the islands, in company with a few partially civilized Indians, and explained to them the advantages of removing to the Mission. They listened attentively to the proposal, and finally consented to go, on promises of protection from their natural enemies being given by the Fathers.

Accordingly, a small vessel was sent to the different islands, and the various tribes were taken one by one, to the Mission of Santa Barbara. But while the last of the Indians were embarking, at the island of San Nicolas, and all were supposed to be on board, a child was missing, and its mother, in great distress was seeking everywhere, without success. Each portion of the vessel was diligently searched ; all the adjacent rocks were examined, but no child could be found. Almost frantic, the mother requested the captain to wait while she went into the interior to search for her child, to which he reluctantly consented.

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As night closed down in darkness, heavy masses of clouds rolled up from the horizon, and gave threatening evidence of a coming storm. All were anxious for the return of the woman and her child, before it broke upon them, but still they came not. The wind began to blow, harder and stronger; the storm was rapidly increasing; and as the groups of Indians on board strained their eyes, trying to discover in the darkness, some object that resembled the returning woman and her child, yet saw them not, there were many sad hearts and anxious countenances that night, on their account. The storm at last came on in all its fury, tossing their little vessel up and down like a feather, and compelled them at last, though reluctantly, to put to sea for safety, before any tidings of the absent ones could be received. Although the cargo of living freight reached Santa Barbara in safety, before the vessel could return for the woman, it was wrecked and entirely lost; and as no other could be obtained at that time, the poor woman had to remain upon the island, where she lived, *alone*, for eighteen years; no doubt forgotten, or given up as long since dead.

After the discovery of gold, it was rumored that San Nicholas was inhabited, and this, no doubt, had its foundation in the fact, that several hunters of the sea otter had seen the print of human footsteps, and they endeavored to discover the whereabouts of the individuals, but could not. Yet, as all the footprints were alike, they concluded that there could be only one person living upon it. Many attempts were made to find out who, and where this strange being was, but without avail, until one of California's oldest pioneers, Mr. Nediver—the gentleman who related the story, and who arrived in this country some twenty-five years ago, and still resides in Santa Barbara—went over to look for her. He having spent many years as a hunter and trapper in the Rocky Mountains, was as expert as an Indian in following a trail, and consequently found but little difficulty in discovering the track, which he followed until he saw a singular object among the rocks upon the sea-shore, near the mouth of a ravine, upon its knees, skinning a seal. Upon approaching, he found it to be a woman, clad in a singular dress of feathers. When she saw him, she jumped up, and, with excessive joy, ran towards him, and seemed almost beside herself with wild delight at the sight, once more, of a human being. In her hand she held a rude knife-blade, that she had made from a piece of old iron, probably obtained from the fragments of some wreck, and which she evidently valued beyond

piece of old iron, probably obtained from the fragments of some wreck, and which she evidently valued beyond anything else in her possession. She was unable to make herself understood, except by signs; in making which, she showed a great amount of intelligence, and signified her willingness to accompany him to Santa Barbara. Here Father Gonzales, of the Mission, took the greatest pains to discover some of the Indians who had been taken from those Islands, eighteen years before, but no one of them could be found, and what became of them is a mystery unto this day. Not one of the Indians, within a circumference of many miles, could be found, who could understand her; so she could communicate only by signs.

It appears from her narrative, that after leaving the vessel in search of her child she wandered about for several hours, and when she found it, the wild dogs which infest the island, even to the present day, had killed and nearly devoured it. We can better imagine the feelings of a mother at such a time, than describe them. When she returned to the spot where she had left the vessel, to tell her sorrows for the loss of her child, that too was gone, and was bearing away her kindred and friends from her sight. Could she have realized, then, that for eighteen long years she must live *alone* in the world, without one kind word of comfort, one cheering look from a friendly eye, or one smile of recognition, it would have been too much for even her wild but womanly nature to bear, and with her, as with us, it is well that we know not the future. From day to day she lived in hope, beguiling the weary hours in providing for her wants. With snares made of her hair she caught birds, and with the skins, properly prepared, she made her clothing. Her needles were neatly made of bone and cactus thorns; her thread was of sinews from the seal. In these and many other articles found in her possession, she exhibited much of the native ingenuity she possessed.

Whether she still remembered her own language or not, will forever remain a mystery. She was very gentle and kind, especially to children, and nothing seemed to please her more than to be near them; and the poor woman would often shed tears while attempting to describe by signs, her own little one which had been killed and eaten by the wild dogs. The sympathy felt for her welfare caused the people to supply her bountifully with everything she needed, and very imprudently, allowed her to eat almost anything she chose, and the result was that in about six months after her escape from her lonely exile, she sickened and died, having, undoubtedly, been killed with kindness.
